# PPMA Enrollment Trends

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## Executive Summary

This report analyzes student enrollment data from Fall 2015 through Spring 2025 to examine how students progress through the Public Policy, Management, and Analytics (PPMA) graduate programs. Using student-level course enrollment records, the analysis examines patterns in course sequencing, course load, time to degree, course retakes, and participation in nonprofit coursework. The goal is to understand how students navigate the curriculum in practice and whether these patterns align with program expectations.

The findings suggest that student progression largely aligns with the program's intended structure, though outcomes are shaped more by structural factors such as course availability and program design than by strict adherence to recommended pathways. Students generally complete foundational coursework early in their programs, with most finishing these courses within their first year. Variation in sequencing appears to reflect course scheduling rather than deviations from program expectations.

Course load patterns fluctuate over time rather than following a consistent trend. Earlier cohorts show higher levels of course overload, while more recent semesters reflect more moderate and balanced enrollment patterns, with most students taking between one and three courses. Time to degree remains stable and closely aligned with program expectations, with most students completing their degrees within approximately 2.5-3 years, with little variation across cohorts.

Additional analyses show that enrollment demand is concentrated in management, finance, and methods/data coursework, with increasing interest in analytical skills over time, while nonprofit and governance courses remain more stable but lower in participation. Differences across programs reflect variation in structure rather than student preferences alone, with MPA following more prescribed pathways, MPP students showing greater flexibility, and MSCA students falling in between.

Participation in nonprofit coursework varies over time, and while course availability may play a role, the relationship is not clearly established. Course retakes are relatively uncommon and are concentrated in a small number of courses rather than distributed broadly across the curriculum.

The findings indicate that the PPMA programs are functioning largely as intended, with student progression patterns shaped more by program design and course availability than by deviations in student behavior. Structural factors, particularly course scheduling and availability, play a central role in shaping how students move through the curriculum and engage with program offerings.

## Introduction

The Department of Public Policy, Management, and Analytics (PPMA) offers graduate programs designed to prepare students for careers in public service, policy, and analytics. As these programs have evolved, it is important to understand how students progress through the curriculum and whether their course-taking patterns align with program expectations.

This report analyzes student enrollment data from Fall 2015 through Spring 2025 to examine trends in student progression and curriculum engagement across PPMA graduate programs. The analysis focuses on course sequencing, course load, time to degree, course retakes, and participation in areas such as nonprofit related coursework. Using student-level enrollment records, the study examines how students navigate the curriculum in practice and how these patterns evolve over time. Understanding these patterns provides insight into how program design and course availability shape student progression through the curriculum. To examine these dynamics, the report is organized around seven key questions related to student progression and course selection, with each section outlining the analytical approach and presenting key findings.

## Data and Methodology

This analysis uses student-level course enrollment data from PPMA, covering Fall 2015 through Spring 2025. The dataset includes term codes, course identifiers, credit attributes, and constructed indicators such as online enrollment, nonprofit coursework, and curriculum flags.

Data cleaning and preparation were conducted using a shared team script to ensure consistency across analyses. The analytical dataset excludes PhD students enrolled in dissertation research courses, online-only students, and students who were not formally enrolled in the PPMA master's programs. The sample is further restricted to students who began within the study period and successfully completed the program by Spring 2025.

Several variables were constructed to support the analysis. Student records were ordered chronologically to create a relative semester index for each student, with program entry defined as the first enrollment in PA 591. Courses were categorized into subject areas, including financial and nonprofit coursework, to analyze enrollment patterns over time. Deviation from the recommended curriculum was measured by identifying courses taken outside required program pathways, and course retakes were identified when a student enrolled in the same course more than once. The analysis relies on descriptive statistics and trend analysis, with results presented through tables and visualizations.

## Analysis Questions and Findings

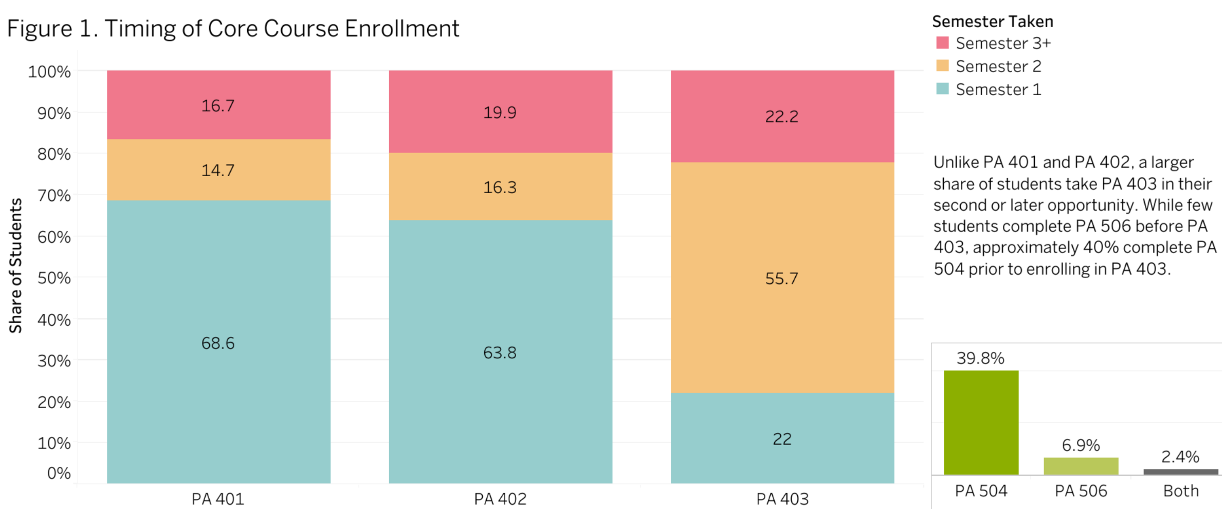
### Question 1: *Are Students Following the Recommended Course Sequence?*

***Method***

Student enrollment records were analyzed to determine whether students follow the recommended course sequence for foundational courses: PA 401, PA 402, and PA 403. For each student, the first and second available opportunity to enroll in each course was calculated based on their program entry term and the season in which each course is typically offered. PA 401 and PA 402 are offered in the fall, while PA 403 is offered in the spring. An adherence indicator was created to identify whether a student completed each course within their first two available opportunities. These rates were then compared across courses to understand differences in when students typically take each requirement. The analysis focuses on overall patterns in course timing rather than strict sequencing, to better reflect how students progress through the program in practice. To explore potential changes over time, a curriculum era variable was created to distinguish between pre- and post-Spring 2025 curriculum periods. However, due to limited post-change data, the analysis primarily focuses on overall patterns rather than differences across curriculum eras. Additionally, prerequisite patterns were examined to identify how many students completed PA 504 or PA 506 prior to enrolling in PA 403.

***Findings***

Figure 1. Timing of Core Course Enrollment




Most students complete foundational courses within their first two available opportunities, though the timing varies across courses. At the course level, PA 401 and PA 402 are most often taken early in the program, with 68.6% and 63.8% of students completing them in their first opportunity, respectively. When including the second opportunity, more than 83% of students in both courses complete them on time. In contrast, only 22% of students take PA 403 in their first opportunity, while 55.7% take it in their second. This pattern is likely driven by course scheduling, as PA 403 is typically offered in the spring semester, meaning fall-entry students encounter it for the first time in their second semester. These patterns suggest that variation in timing is driven more by course availability than by students intentionally deviating from the recommended sequence. Regarding prerequisite patterns, approximately 39.8% of students completed PA 504 before enrolling in PA 403, while only 6.9% completed PA 506 beforehand, and 2.4% completed both prior to PA 403.

***Key Insight***

Foundational coursework is generally completed within the first two available opportunities, with variation in timing driven primarily by course availability rather than intentional deviation from the recommended sequence. Notably, a substantial share of students complete PA 504 before PA 403, suggesting some deviation from the intended course order.

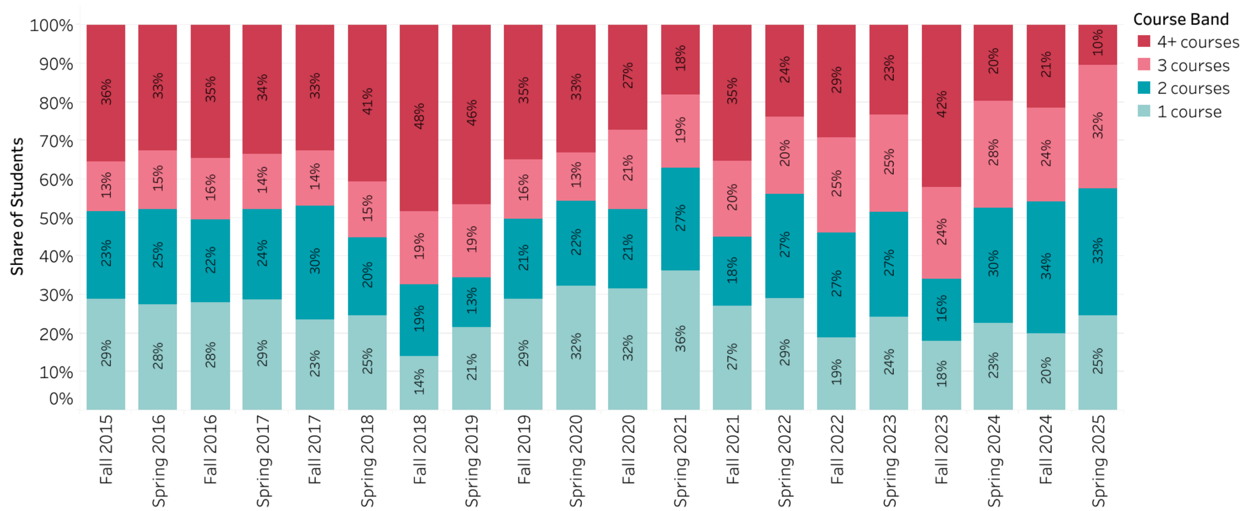
## Question 2: *To what extent are students taking multiple courses within the same semester, and are there signs of course overload?*

***Method***

Student course enrollment records were used to calculate the number of courses taken per student in each academic term. To ensure consistent comparisons, enrollment data were aggregated at the student-term level by grouping courses taken within each semester. Summer terms were excluded to focus on Fall and Spring semesters, which represent most students' standard academic cycle. In addition, one-credit courses were excluded from this analysis to ensure that course load measures reflect substantive academic coursework rather than shorter or supplemental classes. To examine course-taking behavior, student course loads were categorized into discrete bands based on the number of courses taken per semester (e.g., 1 course, 2 courses, 3 courses, and 4 or more courses). This distributional approach allows for analysis of how students allocate their course loads within a semester and how these patterns shift over time. In addition, the percentage of students taking more than three courses in a given semester was used as an indicator of potential course overload. While full-time enrollment is typically defined as nine or more credit hours, taking three or more courses aligns with the threshold at which students typically reach 12 or more credit hours, the point at which tuition costs no longer increase. As a result, this threshold reflects both an academically heavier course load, and a potential financial incentive for students to take on additional coursework. Trends were analyzed over time by examining changes in the distribution of course load categories across semesters, allowing for identification of both typical enrollment patterns and variation in course-taking intensity. Additional analysis of credit hour distributions is provided in the Appendix for reference.

### *Findings*

Figure 2. Distribution of Student Course Loads by Semester




Student course loads vary substantially over time, with noticeable shifts in the dominant course-load category across semesters. From Fall 2015 through Spring 2020, the largest share of students was generally enrolled in four or more courses, indicating that heavier course loads were common in earlier years. This pattern changes sharply in Fall 2020 and Spring 2021, when the highest share of students shifts to the one-course category, suggesting a temporary move toward lighter course loads. By Fall 2021, the distribution shifts again, with four or more courses once more representing the largest share of students. In Spring 2022, course loads are more evenly distributed across categories, with one-course enrollments slightly higher, followed by two-course enrollments, and then four-or more courses, indicating a period of greater balance and variability in course-taking behavior. In later semesters, the pattern continues to fluctuate. For example, in Fall 2023, a relatively high proportion of students (approximately 42 percent) are again enrolled in four or more courses, suggesting a temporary return to heavier course loads. However, in the most recent terms (Spring 2024 through Spring 2025), the distribution becomes more concentrated in two-course loads, alongside comparable levels in one- and three-course enrollments. Overall, course taking behavior does not follow a single stable pattern over time. Instead, periods of heavier course loads alternate with shifts toward lighter or more moderate enrollment. Recent semesters suggest a tendency toward more moderate course loads, with enrollment distributed across one to three courses. Student course load patterns could be related to course availability, graduation timelines, or tuition incentives, though further analysis would be needed to confirm these relationships.

### *Key Insight*

Course load patterns fluctuate over time, with earlier semesters characterized by frequent course overload and more recent semesters trending toward moderate and balanced enrollment across one to three courses.

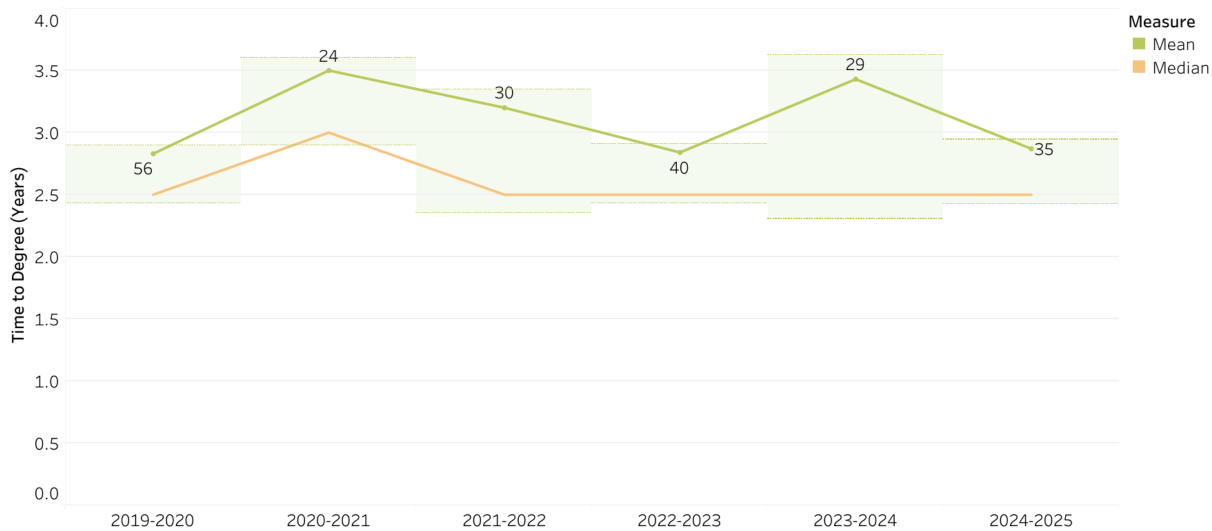
## Question 3: *How has average time to degree completion changed over time?*

### *Method*

To examine trends in time to degree completion, program completers were identified as students who enrolled in the capstone course (PA 590 or PA 592) in their final observed term. Time to degree was calculated by converting each student's start and graduation term into a sequential index that accounts for Spring, Summer, and Fall terms, and computing the number of terms elapsed between program entry and graduation. Completion time in years was derived by dividing the number of terms by two. Students were then grouped into graduation cohorts based on academic year, and cohorts prior to 2018–2019 were excluded to reduce bias from incomplete early enrollment records. Completion time trends were assessed using mean and median values by graduation cohort, with standard deviation bands included to capture the degree of variation within each cohort. A distributional analysis was also conducted to examine variation in student outcomes across six completion time categories.

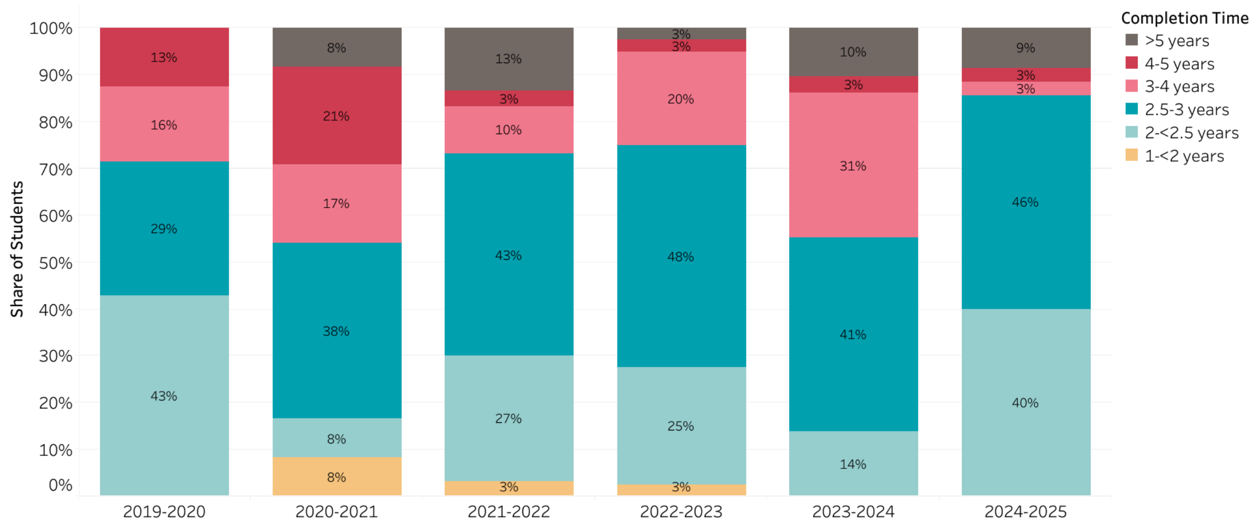
### *Findings*

Figure 3. Program Completion Time by Academic Year




Average time to degree completion remains broadly consistent across cohorts, though some variation exists from year to year. The median completion time is stable at 2.5 years across most cohorts, rising slightly to 3.0 years in 2020–2021. Mean completion time fluctuates more noticeably, ranging from approximately 2.8 years in 2019–2020 and 2024–2025 to a peak of 3.5 years in 2020–2021, likely reflecting the disruptions of the COVID-19 pandemic on that cohort. Standard deviation bands reveal that within-cohort variation also differs across years. The 2020–2021 and 2023–2024 cohorts show wider bands, indicating greater spread in individual completion times, while the 2024–2025 cohort shows a notably narrower band, suggesting that recent graduates are completing the program more consistently around the mean.

Figure 4. Distribution of Program Completion Time by Academic Year




The distributional analysis reinforces this trend: in 2024–2025, 86% of graduates completed the program within 3 years, with 40% finishing in 2–2.5 years and 46% in 2.5–3 years. In contrast, earlier cohorts such as 2019–2020 show a more even spread, with higher shares in the 3–4 year and 4–5 year ranges. It should be noted that the 2019–2020 cohort's relatively short mean completion time likely reflects incomplete early enrollment records rather than genuinely faster graduation.

***Key Insight***

Time to degree is stable across cohorts and closely aligned with the program's intended 2.5 to 3-year timeline. Recent cohorts show both an increasing concentration of graduates completing within three years and a narrowing standard deviation, suggesting that students are not only progressing more efficiently but also more consistently over time.

## Question 4: *How have enrollment patterns across concentrations and elective courses changed over time, and what do these trends suggest about shifts in student preferences?*

***Method***

To examine shifts in enrollment patterns across concentrations and elective coursework, course enrollment records were cleaned and standardized to ensure consistency across curriculum changes. Courses were grouped into policy-relevant topic areas (e.g. methods, finance, governance, nonprofit) based on course content and mapped to concentration areas using a course-based classification. Primary measures include annual enrollment counts by topic and concentration, aggregated at the academic year level. Concentrations were inferred from students' later coursework to better reflect intended specialization. Trend analysis was conducted using time-series visualizations of enrollments by topic and concentration, allowing for identification of both gradual shifts in student preferences and structural changes associated with curriculum updates.

### *Findings*

Figure 5. Number of Elective Courses Offered by Topic Area and Academic Year

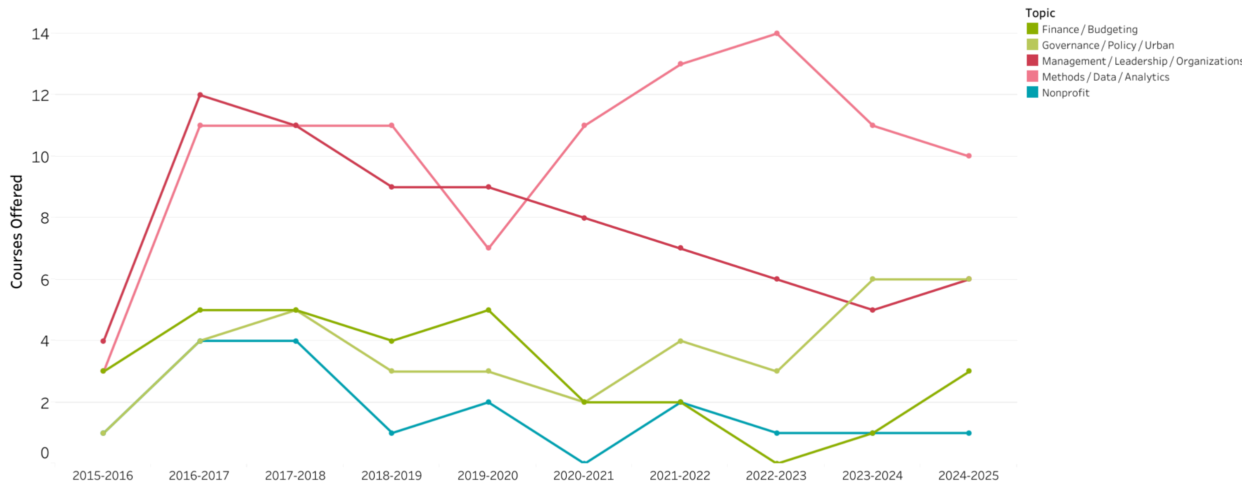
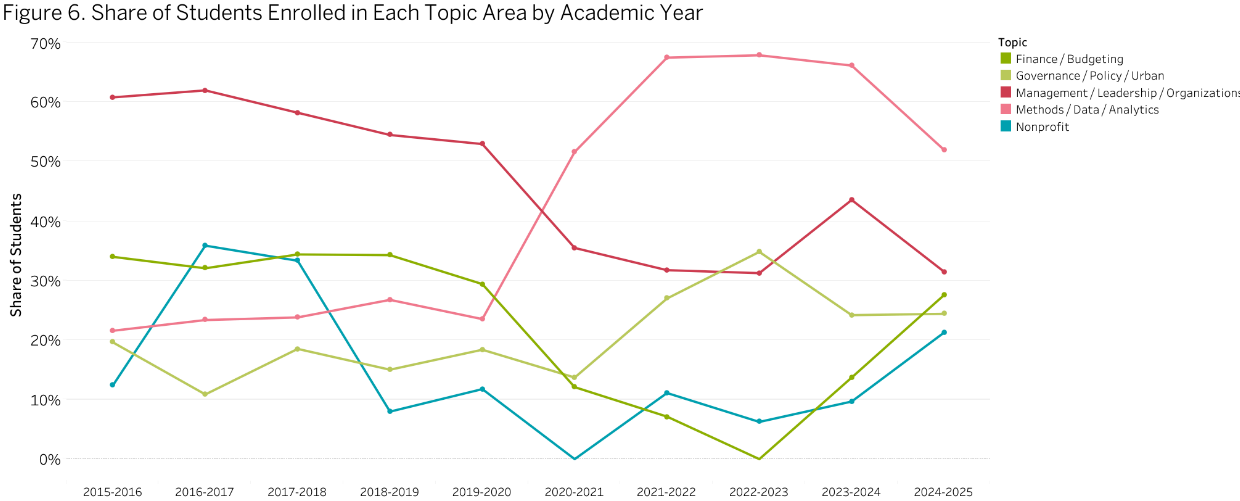



Figure 6. Share of Students Enrolled in Each Topic Area by Academic Year




Enrollment patterns across concentrations and elective courses show a shift in student preferences over time, especially toward data and analytics coursework. Courses in this area, including PA 431, PA 434, PA 541, and the survey and advanced methods sequence, have increased both in total enrollments and as a share of students, pointing to growing demand for technical and analytical skills. In contrast, finance and budgeting courses such as PA 550 to PA 552 and nonprofit courses such as PA 571 to PA 573 remain relatively stable, attracting steady but not increasing interest. Governance, policy, and management courses, including PA 526, PA 563, and PA 422, vary more from year to year, which suggests that enrollment in these areas is influenced by cohort composition and course offerings rather than long-term changes in preferences. The increase in data-related courses remains even when measured as a percentage of students, which indicates that this is not simply due to changes in cohort size.

The relationship between demand and course availability also shapes these patterns. In some cases, declines in enrollment occur at the same time as reductions in the number of courses offered in a topic area, suggesting that the change is driven by limited availability rather than reduced interest. For example, drops in nonprofit or finance enrollments often coincide with fewer courses being offered in those areas. At the same time, demand for data and analytics courses continues to grow even when the number of available courses does not increase at the same pace, which suggests that students are concentrating into a smaller set of offerings. Overall, the results show that enrollment trends reflect both changing student preferences and the mix of courses offered each year, with the strongest growth in data and analytics.

***Key Insight***

Enrollment is concentrated in management, finance, and methods/data courses, with demand for analytical and technical skills showing steady growth over time, while nonprofit and governance courses maintain more stable but lower levels of participation.

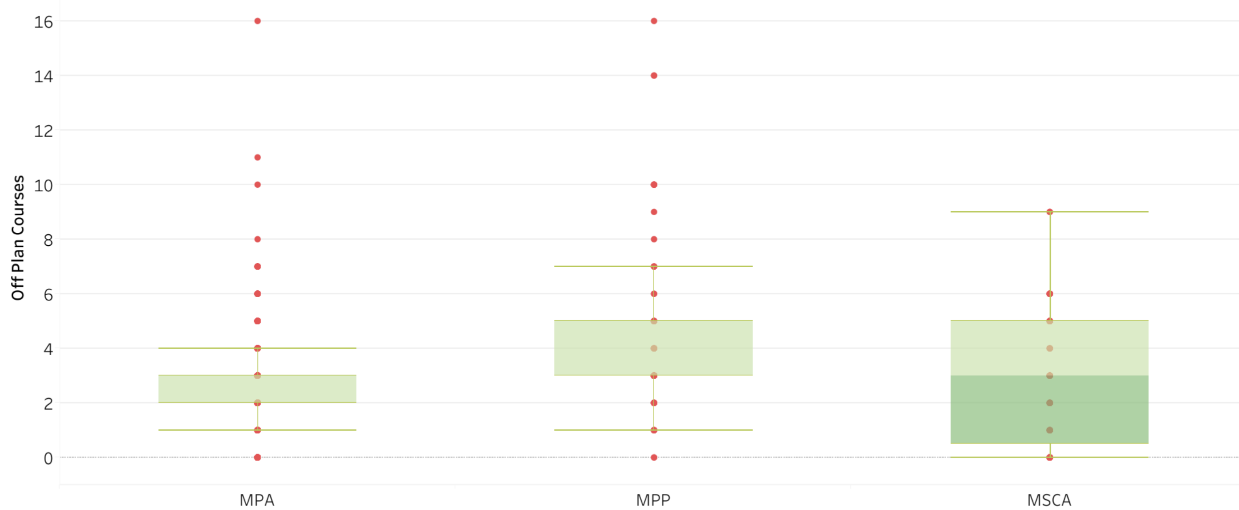
## **Question 5:** ***To what extent do students deviate from the recommended course plan across the three programs (MPA, MPP, and MSCA)?***

***Method***

Students were assigned to MPA, MPP, or MSCA programs based on signature course enrollment. Each student's course history was then compared to the required core and concentration courses defined in the PPMA curriculum using standardized course identifiers. Deviation from the course plan was measured by identifying courses that fell outside the required curriculum ("off-plan") and counting the total number of off-plan courses per student. Program-specific requirements were applied for each degree, along with a shared set of concentration courses, to ensure consistency across programs. Outliers were reviewed manually. A small number of students, particularly in the MPA program, had unusually high counts of off-plan courses, often reflecting extended enrollment periods or inclusion of undergraduate coursework. These cases were interpreted cautiously. Boxplots were used to examine the distribution of off-plan courses per student, allowing for comparison of both typical deviation levels and variation within each program.

### *Findings*

Figure 7. Deviation from Course Plan by Program




The MPA program shows the lowest levels of deviation, with most students staying within the pre-approved list of concentration courses. In contrast, MPP students exhibit higher levels of deviation, reflected in both a higher median and a wider spread of off-plan courses. This likely reflects greater flexibility in the MPP curriculum, which does not rely on a predefined list of electives in the same way as the MPA and MSCA programs. MSCA students fall between these two patterns, combining required coursework with a more limited set of additional electives. Off-plan courses tend to cluster in a small number of areas, particularly courses such as UPP 530, POLS 551, and POLS 553, suggesting that students are expanding their coursework in targeted ways rather than deviating randomly. Overall, differences in deviation appear to be driven more by program structure than by individual student behavior, with MPA following a more structured path, MPP allowing greater flexibility, and MSCA falling in between.

### *Key Insight*

Deviation from the recommended course plan varies by program and is largely driven by differences in program structure, with MPP allowing more flexibility and MPA remaining the most structured.

## Question 6: *How has student participation in nonprofit coursework changed over time, and what explains these trends?*

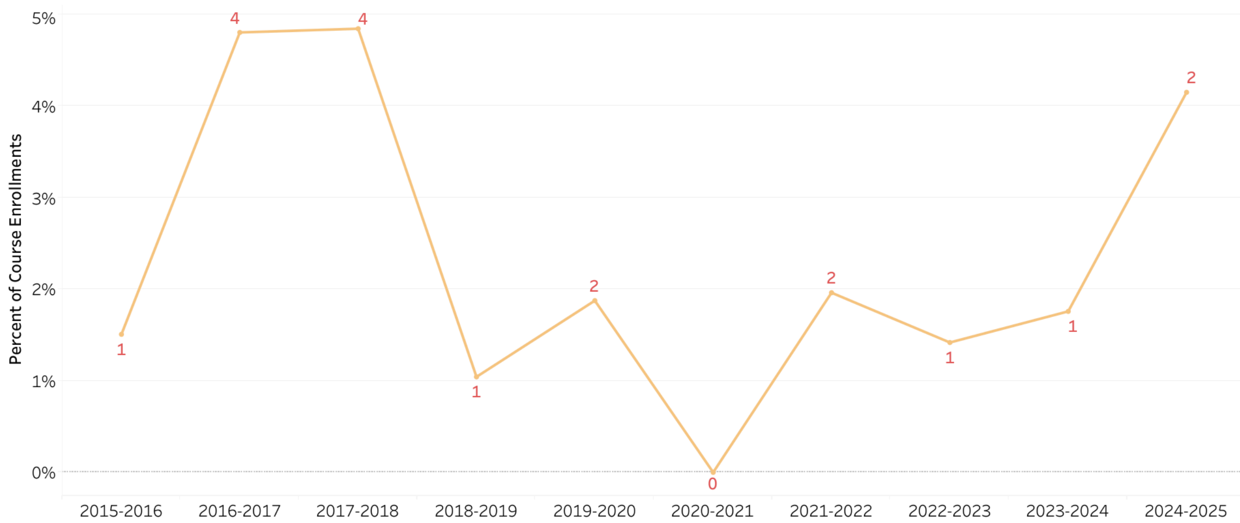
### *Method*

To examine trends in nonprofit course participation, courses were classified as nonprofit-related based on course content. For each academic year, the share of total course enrollments attributable to nonprofit coursework was calculated to track changes in participation over time. The number of nonprofit course offerings (measured as distinct CRNs) was also incorporated to evaluate whether observed variation in participation reflects underlying student demand or is driven by constraints in course availability.

### *Findings*

Figure 8. Share of PPMA Course Enrollments in Nonprofit Courses by Academic Year

Numbers indicate courses offered per academic year; AY 2020-2021 excluded (no courses offered)




Student participation in nonprofit coursework fluctuates over time rather than following a clear upward or downward trend. Participation is relatively higher in the 2016-2018 academic years, reaching approximately 4-5% of total enrollments, before dropping sharply to around 1% in 2018-2019. After this decline, participation gradually increases but remains relatively low (between 1.5-2%) through the early 2020s. Notably, the 2020-2021 academic year is excluded due to the absence of nonprofit course offerings. In the most recent year (2024-2025), participation increases, though course offerings remain limited (two courses). Similar levels of availability in prior years were associated with lower participation, suggesting that the increase may reflect a single-year fluctuation rather than a consistent pattern. These fluctuations loosely align with changes in the number of nonprofit courses offered each year, although offerings remain limited (typically one to two courses annually). Overall, the pattern suggests that course availability may influence participation, though the limited variation in offerings makes it difficult to draw strong conclusions about underlying student demand.

### *Key Insight*

Participation in nonprofit coursework appears to be influenced by course availability, though limited variation in offerings makes it difficult to assess underlying student demand.

## *Question 7: To what extent do students retake courses, and which courses are most frequently repeated?*

### *Method*

To examine course retake patterns, a retake indicator was created by identifying instances in which a student enrolled in the same course number more than once. Research oriented courses (PA 494, PA 593, and PA 596), which are designed to span multiple semesters, were excluded from this analysis. Retake rates were calculated at the student level to determine the share of students who repeated at least one course. Additionally, retake counts were aggregated by course to identify which courses were most frequently retaken.

### *Findings*

Figure 9. Course Retake Rate Among Program Completers

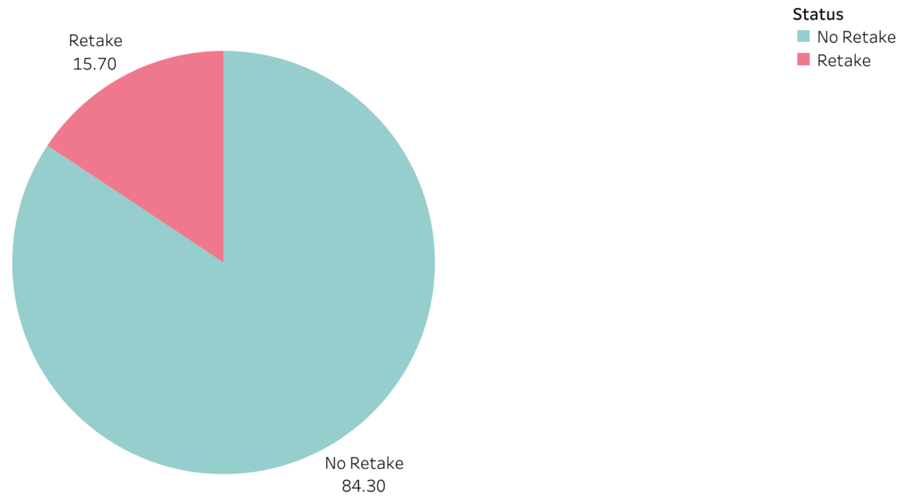
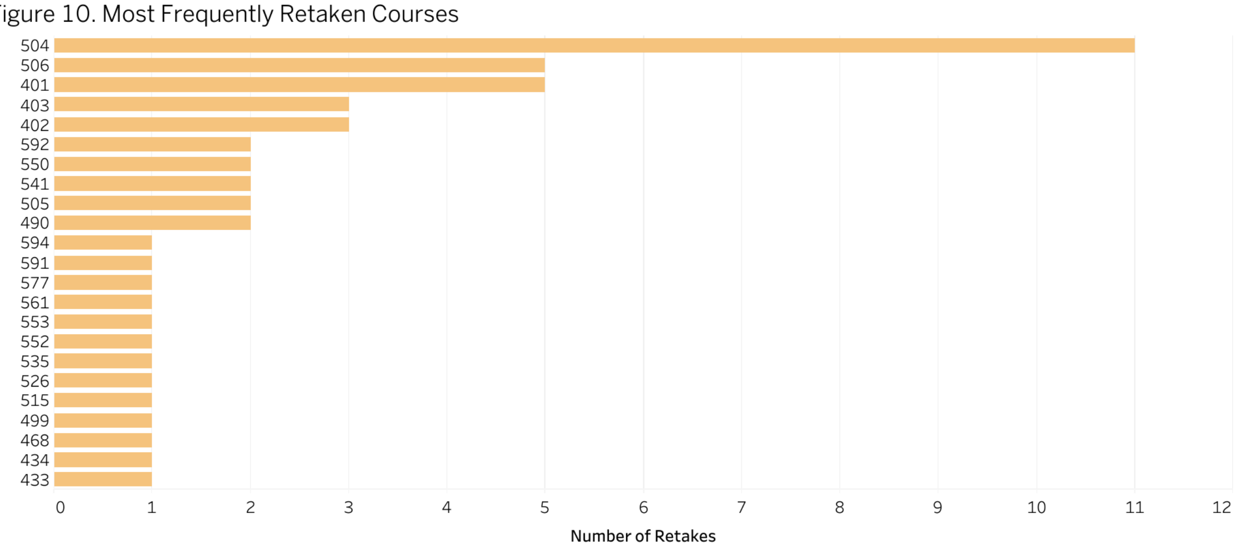



Figure 10. Most Frequently Retaken Courses



The analysis indicates that course repetition is relatively uncommon among program completers. Approximately 15.7% of students retook at least one course, while 84.3% completed their coursework without any repeated enrollment.
Among the courses that are retaken, repetition is concentrated in a small subset of classes rather than distributed across the curriculum. PA 504 shows the highest number of retakes (11 instances), followed by PA 506 and PA 401 (5 instances each), and PA 403 and PA 402 (3 instances each). Most other courses exhibit only one or two instances of repeated enrollment.

***Key Insight***

Course retakes are relatively uncommon and concentrated in a small number of courses, suggesting that repetition is linked to specific course challenges rather than a widespread issue across the curriculum.

## Conclusion

The findings from this analysis suggest that student progression through PPMA graduate programs is largely aligned with program expectations, with most students following structured course pathways, more recent semesters reflecting a more balanced distribution across one to three courses, and students completing their degrees within the intended timeframe. These patterns indicate that the current program structure is functioning effectively in supporting student success.

Across all seven questions, the analysis consistently points to structural factors, particularly course availability and program design, as the primary drivers of student behavior, rather than individual decision-making alone. Enrollment demand is concentrated in management, finance, and methods/data coursework, reflecting growing interest in analytical skills, while participation in nonprofit and governance courses remains more stable. Differences in course-taking patterns across MPA, MPP, and MSCA programs largely reflect variation in program structure and flexibility rather than student preferences. Similarly, participation in nonprofit coursework may be influenced by course availability, though the relationship is not clearly established.

This analysis has several limitations worth noting. The dataset includes only students who successfully completed the program, which means the patterns observed may not reflect the experiences of students who withdrew or took leaves of absence. Program assignments for MPA, MPP, and MSCA were inferred from course-taking patterns rather than official enrollment records, which may introduce some misclassification. Additionally, because the analysis relies solely on enrollment data, it is not possible to directly measure student intent or preferences.

Finally, the absence of grade data means that the reasons behind course retakes, whether due to academic difficulty or other factors, cannot be determined from this analysis alone.

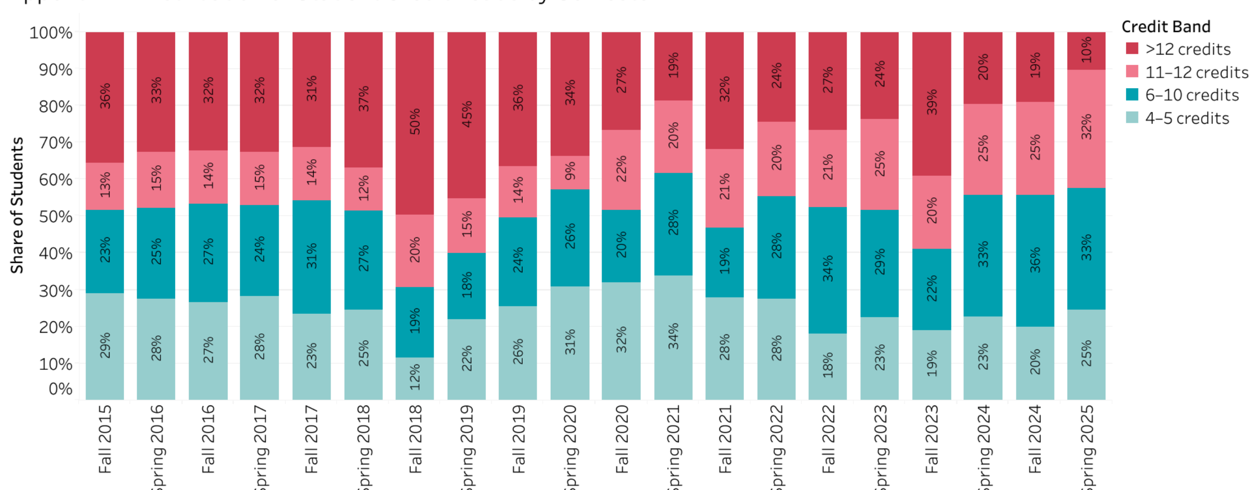
The findings from our analysis suggest several opportunities for program-level improvements. Given the influence of course availability and scheduling on student enrollment patterns, expanding sections in high demand areas such as finance, methods/data courses, and growing areas like the nonprofit sector, may help reduce bottlenecks. Additionally, more intentional scheduling of required and commonly paired courses could support more balanced course loads across semesters. Increasing flexibility beyond a strictly fall or spring course offering structure may further allow students to distribute coursework more evenly and reduce periods of overload. These adjustments could better align course availability with student demand and improve overall progression through the program.

Overall, these findings highlight the central role that program design and course scheduling play in shaping how students engage with the curriculum. As the PPMA programs continue to evolve, attention to course availability and structural flexibility will remain important in ensuring that students can progress through the curriculum in ways that align with both program expectations and their individual goals.

# Appendix

Appendix A. Appendix A presents the distribution of student credit loads by semester, serving as a complement to the main analysis in Question 2. While the primary findings focus on course counts, the credit-based distribution offers additional context on overall enrollment intensity and supports interpretation of course-taking patterns over time.

Appendix A. Distribution of Student Credit Loads by Semester




Appendix B. Master Dataset

Appendix C. Master Data Dictionary
Appendix D. Reproducible Report (PDF)
Appendix E. Reproducible Report (Quarto)